The seven levels of classification

Traditionally, when classifying **organisms**, scientists sort them into groups on seven levels. This is known as a **hierarchical system**. Each level classifies the organism in more detail. The first, and highest, of these levels is **Kingdom**. Organisms can be in either the **animal** or **plant** kingdom, or in other kingdoms such as **fungi** and **bacteria**.

☞ **1** What kingdom would you place the following organisms in?

platypus _____ carrot _____ frog _____ rose _____

Next, organisms are sorted by their structure. This refers to whether an animal has a backbone (chordata), or a soft body or a hard outer shell. This level is called the **Phylum**.

Organisms are then sorted by **Class**, then **Order**, **Family**, **Genus** and **Species**. Each level goes into more detail about the structure, shape and other characteristics of the organism. The group names are in Latin or Greek, but they are often similar to common English names. For example, Class *mammalia* means mammals.

☞ **2** Use the word bank to fill out the table. Note, some words are used more than once.

Word bank

Insecta	Animal	Mammalia
Marsupialia	Chordata	Octopoda

	Feather-tailed glider	**Bogong moth**	**Blue-ringed octopus**
Kingdom:	A_____	A_____	A_____
Phylum:	C_____	Arthropoda	Mollusca
Class:	M_____	I_____	Cephalopoda
Order:	M_____	Lepidoptera	O_____
Family:	Acrobatidae	Noctuidae	Octopodidae
Genus:	*Acrobates*	*Agrotis*	*Hapalochlaena*
Species:	*pygmaeus*	*infusa*	*maculosa*

© Beth Montgomery and Blake Education 2012

© Blake Education 978 1 92571 040 3 Achieve! Science Understanding Biology Yr 7 - 8